13743

741.569
CHA

THE CLASSIC POPULAR
AMAR CHITRA KATHA
1967-2007

Shiv Nadar University Central Library Chithera Gautam Budh Nagar 203207
13743
Accession No.....
Signature.....

NANDINI CHANDRA

SHIV NADAR UNIVERSITY
CENTRAL LIBRARY

(6)

YODA PRESS

CHAPTER ONE

The Serious Comic(s)

We do not see things as they are, we see them as we are

— Anaïs Nin

Amar Chitra Katha (hereafter ACK) started its career in 1967, at a time when *Phantom*[1] was at the top of the charts in the Indian comic market. Anant Pai, the founder-editor of ACK comics, who in the early 1960s was an editor at Indrajal Comics (*The Times of India*), 'understood' the market. He understood that *Superman*, the American superhero might leave the Indian audience cold, whereas *Phantom*, since it touched upon the experience of the colonised, however distantly (the darkest jungles of Africa) or abusively (leaving no orientalist cliché

[1] *Phantom*, one of the first costumed superheroes, conceived by Lee Falk, an American, first appeared as a newspaper comic strip in 1936. While it received moderate success in America as a newspaper strip and no success in England, Falk is supposed to have made his fortune in the outlying colonies, from Australia and India to Sweden and New Zealand. However, it never made it to the darkest jungles of Africa where it was situated. See Kai Friese, 'White Skin, Black Mask' in *Transition Online*, Issue 80, http://www.transitionmagazine.com/online/whiteskin.htm, accessed on 15 March 2007.

untouched) would continue to click with an Indian audience.[2] One could argue that ACK was nothing but an endeavour to get the entire history of colonisation (as Pai understood it), mounted onto the comic mode. There were no masked crime-fighters in purple skin-suits, but each issue had a superhero who attempted to wage war against foreign oppression, whether the 'foreigner' was the *Asura*, Muslim or British. What is more, the superhero usually fought on behalf of Hindus or those under the protective net of Hindu rulers.

This Hindu liberation theology was necessarily about dramatising the repeated abuse suffered under colonial rule, tapping the masochistic nerve of the colonised Hindu as a way of guaranteeing sales. In the process, it managed to thoroughly Hinduise a moral high ground and righteous victimhood. The superior claims of the nation over this moral high ground were dealt with by conflating the Hindu with the national. Preserving the 'national heritage' of India was about transferring the right of outrage from the Hindu to the nation, simultaneously evoking the Hinduness of that nation.

Keeping all of this in mind, we explore in the present volume how ACK's comic medium deploys its images, narratives and myths in order to make the transition from Hindu to national seem so natural. The entire corpus of ACKs could in fact be reduced to a communal ideological apparatus, with roots going back to the early 19th century ideas of nation and nationalism. However, the curious thing about ACK is that it *seems* to operate mostly in the interstices between different ideological systems, providing as it were an unblinkered, unmediated history/voice of the people. Perhaps this appears to be true because its research and analysis wing builds its stories from different epochs of Hindu history—from Vedic times for its foundational sense of Hinduness to different moments of Hindu revivalism since. The combination of historical sweep with a quintessentially modern format creates a kind of immediacy for the Hindu archetype, or a mythological reality effect. The reality effect further combines the hoary Hinduness with a modern scientific Indian identity to produce a seamless continuity between the past and present, as it were.

The authoritative sources of the ACK stories allowed the comics to style themselves as 'classical'. However, the classics were at once seen as

2 Star Comics had offered to sell the distribution rights for *Superman* to Indrajal Comics, but Pai decided to favour the case of *Phantom*, understanding its far greater popularity in the subcontinent. ACK was eventually able to completely capture *Phantom's* market.

the articulation of a popular sentiment, popular being identified as the voice of anyone who could be shown to have a life on the pages of the comic. In a convoluted way, the classical became the source of the popular, insofar as the characters from the classical texts, no matter how élite, were rendered in the comic mode, dramatised and fleshed out to reveal intimate bedroom details about themselves.

The present volume also looks at the slips and slides between the construction of a would-be orthodox Hinduism in the 19th century, and the vague outline of an alternate nationalism present in the stories of ACK dating to a more amorphous past. To give an example, the idea of bhakti (religious devotionalism) enunciated in various ACKs is drawn from the *Gita* rather than from the radical Bhakti movement of the medieval period. In fact, ACK seeks to imbue even the message of the lower-caste saints with this brahminical universality. The centrality given to brahmins in these comics does much more than merely stifle the saints' message. Narratives which either cast the 'good' reformist brahmin against the 'bad' brahmin who cannot see the oneness of god for the sheer profusion of idols and rituals, or else blend the two in the figure of the contrite brahmin regretting his oppression of the saints, indicate not merely a falsification of history, but also a mimicking of a longer historical process of reformism. Historically, this reformism and the complex techniques for restoring Brahminical hegemony grew in direct response to the democratic and radical challenge posed by Buddhism. Insofar as ACKs offer us a glimpse into the *longue durée* of Brahminical consolidation, they inadvertently help to explode the postcolonial commonsense of 'Hindu' as a radically new construct, merely a product of colonial bureaucracy rather than something with roots in a real historical timeframe. They also help us in understanding the far deeper hold of Hindu structures on the so-called secular mind.

There is often considerable difficulty in distinguishing between the monolithic Hindu tradition and identity and the more disparate and disconnected cults and practices, aspects such as pilgrimage networks, which may evoke the presence of a pervasive cultural structure, undeniably, if not strictly, Hindu.[3] In other words, it is very

3 See Yvette Claire Rosser 'Imagining Jambudvipa: Co-Deconstructing Post Modern Post Orientalist Post-Colonial Contra Essentialist Anti-Hegemonic Occi-centric Meta Theories and Other Such Intellectual Hyperbole and Re-Restoring Agency to the Indian Subject Who is a Twentieth Century Scholar', online document, http://www.infinityfoundation.com/mandala/s_es/s_es_rosse_jambud_frameset.htm, accessed on 9 August 2006.

difficult to unravel local micro-practices from the more clearly organised macro-traditions. What I hope to show is the manner in which wittingly or unwittingly, the various players in the making of ACK comics undermined the monolithic national vision for a more locally nuanced version, as much as they capitulate to the former. For one, the need to produce 'Indian' tales day after day led ACK's creators to ferret out stories in the name of folk, mythology and freedom fighters from different epochs and places. Despite being cast in nationalist hues, the sheer number of tales represented an inadvertent conflict of schools, sects and philosophies was represented under this broad majoritarian banner. While it is true that conflicts were always neutralised or the different conflicting schools were made to seem harmonious, the underlying tenor of all ACKs (especially suitable to the biographical mode), resonated with intrigue and deception as an invariable part of everyday life. While the central protagonist might have been innocent of these intrigues, the thrust of the comics lay in their dramatic details—the sheer hostility and conflict to which the hero or heroine was subjected by the world at large. This was the picture of the world offered to an ostensibly child reader, even as the last page conveyed a reconciliation and overcoming of all odds.

Similarly, the artists brought their own training and tastes to bear upon their creations. Editorial briefs and protocols were violated periodically to stamp the drawings with their inimitable signatures. This meant that local traditions, practices that were associated with a certain western Indian fit—a mix of Maharashtrian, Konkani and Kannadiga—were disguised in the name of nation, and accommodated to the cosmopolitanism of Bombay. Thus artists who drew the Punjabi, Malayalam and Tamil titles were referred to as regional artists, as opposed to the Marathi and Konkani artists who were privileged enough to draw the 'national' titles.

The artists also participated in a shared culture of being migrants, coming from different provinces to the bustling city of Bombay. In other words, most of them shared the deep fascination of and for the rootless modern. And this preoccupation with making it modern, in the strictest sense of updating and reifying for a new generation, as well as in the vaguest sense of fulfilling a dominant aesthetic requirement to make it provocative and erotic made it a worthy rival of the film industry, whose influence was so close as to be almost invisible, and yet be internal to it.

There are in fact very few references to the film industry and very few overlaps between those who worked for both media. ACK's self-projection as an educational tool for children further marks the distance between them. However, the film industry wears, just like ACK, a national mask, carrying the ensuing contradiction between the cosmopolitan climate of Bombay and the upholding of a decisively north Indian feudal profile. There are more affinities: all the illustrators of ACK used cinematic techniques of storytelling such as close-ups, perspective shots, long cuts, top angles, silhouettes, etc. The imbrication of ACK visuals in a Hindi film aesthetic, however muted, is sought to be mediated by local practices drawn from artisanal traditions, the way a line curls, the way the sketches are left unfinished or figures made to look squat or sculptural, or else overly rounded, giving them a primordial look. There is an urge to mask the modern innovations associated with a western aesthetic. Insofar as Hindi films, with their unapologetic embrace of the modern, have the power to expose (by association) ACK's pretence to an unmediated 'primordiality', one can perhaps guess why the makers of ACK would want to distance themselves from the Bombay film industry.

The cultural biography of ACKs is, however, premised on the disavowal of the different local influences of its producers for the sake of a realist national imaginary. At the outset, we will look at the process by which these various biases are sought to be absorbed into the skein of the national. What is the process of manufacture through which the local becomes national, the popular classic, and vice versa?

ACK may represent an ideal Hindu state underwritten by the ideology of feudalism, but it derives its profit from the bourgeois capitalist state. The concept of nation enshrined in ACKs thus overlaps two sets of hierarchies. ACK, however, tries to circumvent the 'real' contradictions inherent in heterogeneity—to bypass the conflicts of class, caste and gender—by subsuming them under a false heterogeneity of titles drawn from the seemingly varied genres of history, legend and myth. What masquerades as novel, different, and plural, can actually be subsumed by the bourgeois genre of biography, so much so that the nation itself is identified in terms of an individual's inspiring life-narrative. Hero worship, an integral part of children's literature is then put into the service of the life-narrative designed to foster national feeling. The premise of identification between hero and child is then magically effected through a common religious bonding. This complex

dynamic suggests that an examination of ACK's status as children's literature would be a worthwhile starting point for our exploration.

I

Children's literature is here referred to in the strict sense of a function of the market, 'as a specialised sub-sector within the culture industry' created to suit the image an adult has of what a child is or should be at any specific historical moment. My focus on ACK's comic medium is intended to highlight its marginality from the literary canon, and its simultaneous centrality as a popular genre. But whether or not it has an amorphous audience like most popular genres, the fact that it projects itself as juvenile literature provides it with 'a biologically captive pre-determined audience'.[4] ACK's ideological charge consequently draws upon two sources: the innocence that it projects onto its child audience, and the reliance of its narrative on the naturalising effect of the photographic realism of its drawings, intended to seduce a more adult audience. This in turn is modelled on the post-Renaissance European academic realism first adapted to Indian themes by Raja Ravi Varma in the late 19th century.

Such a potent combination of innocence and naturalness becomes the means through which ACK charts a cultural history of India. These attributes enable it to *denote* rather than *connote*, precluding other recordings of the past and establishing its hegemony over other styles of documentation. In tandem, ACK summons its witnesses from among the fabrications of 19th-century orientalist-nationalist writers. At the same time, it sustains its charge of an alternative historiography by projecting a southern-Indian/west-coast narrative, replete with the Vaishnava ideology of its founder Pai as the alibi for an untrammelled proto-Hindu nationalist consciousness. The role of distributive channels in disseminating symbols and icons associated with this legacy then needs to be explained through the monopolistic tactics deployed by ACK's founder-editor Anant Pai, who is also the marketing genius behind its success. In addition to the distribution

[4] Ariel Dorfman and Armand Mattelart, *How to Read Donald Duck: Imperialist Ideology in the Disney Comic*, translated and with an Introduction by David Kunzle (International General, 1975), p. 30.

network, we need to understand the production process, the technologies involved, and the manner in which the different agents in this vast administration interact. At the same time, the cultural product that is ACK cannot remain free from the various institutions of the state, political parties, the educational apparatus and different financial and industrial interests who ultimately regulate the conditions of its existence.

One goal of our investigation then is to see how ACK negotiates with these numerous regulating mechanisms and circumvents the different censors set in motion by them, by 'disguising the future ideal system as past in order to criticize the present'.[5] There are, of course, moments or entire comics which manage to produce a liberating reading, straddling diverse contradictions as it were. But even as we stress these rare historically conjunctural moments, they are recognised to be rare.

To define ACKs status as a commodity and mass-produced object, one must necessarily visit Walter Benjamin's 'The Work of Art in the Age of Mechanical Reproduction'. Benjamin argues that 'the technique of reproduction detaches the reproduced object from the domain of tradition'.[6] The increasing reproduction of images is usually associated with a desacralisation of society. But within the Indian context, 'mechanically reproduced images continue to participate in the reality of the "objects" or personages depicted and this participation—the active association of the image with its sacred source—helps to account for the nature, popularity and ubiquity of images in modern India'.[7]

The business of the chromolithography press which started at the turn of the 20th century was firmly entrenched in the preservation of

[5] This line is taken from the introduction to *The Prison Notebooks of Antonio Gramsci* (edited by Quentin Hoare and Nowell Smith, International Publishers, 1971, p. 24). It describes Gramsci's critique of the Gentile reforms in the Italian education system under the Mussolini government: 'The apparently conservative eulogy of the old curriculum in fact often represents a device which allowed Gramsci to circumvent the prison censor, by disguising the future ideal system as the past in order to criticize the present.'

[6] Walter Benjamin, 'The Work of Art in the Age of Mechanical Reproduction' in *Illuminations* (Fontana/Collins, 1972), p. 233.

[7] Stephen R. Inglis, 'Suitable for Framing: The Work of a Modern Master' in Lawrence A. Babb and Susan S. Wadley (eds), *Media and Transformation of Religion in South Asia* (University of Pennsylvania Press, 1995), p. 52.

tradition, placing it in a counter-trajectory to the desacralising impulse of mass reproduction. It would be useful to examine the relationship of what Benjamin calls 'aura'[8] to Marx's commodity fetishism, since the paradox of the religious print seems to be that it continues to exude a ritual interest in spite of its commodity status, richly and variously theorised by scholars working on different aspects of bazaar art.[9]

While the form of the sacred is undoubtedly altered by the techniques of mass reproduction, the intensity of the reverence evoked by these picture gods seems to have increased in dizzying proportion to their reproduction, and also to have brought the gods within the reach of several marginalised communities. According to Anuradha Kapur, the sheer profusion and ubiquity of these picture gods has enabled the recruitment of the Hindu middle class as a political force, while Christopher Pinney avers that it has enabled a class of rural consumers, usually dalits, to gain access to these gods outside the forbidden precincts of the temples, creating a distinctly political sacredness for these images.[10]

[8] According to Benjamin, the unique aura or authenticity of the work of art exists outside the domain of commodity culture,

> that which withers in the age of mechanical reproduction is the aura of the work of art...the technique of reproduction detaches the reproduced object from the domain of tradition. By making many reproductions it substitutes a plurality of copies for a unique existence. And in permitting the reproduction to meet the beholder or listener in his own particular situation, it reactivates the object reproduced. These two processes lead to a tremendous shattering of tradition....

See 'The Work of Art in the Age of Mechanical Reproduction' in *Illuminations*, p. 233. In contrast, commodity fetishism, is the aura or exchange value which attaches to commodities when the labour and relations between human beings in the act of production is alienated as 'objective characteristics of the products of labour themselves'.

[9] See Christopher Pinney, *Photos of the Gods: The Printed Image and Political Struggle in India* (Oxford University Press, 2004); Kajri Jain, 'Figures of Locality and Tradition: Commercial Cinema and the Networks of Visual Print Capitalism in Maharashtra' in Ajay Sinha and Raminder Kaur (eds), *Bollyworld: Indian Popular Cinema Through a Transnational Lens* (Sage Publications, 2005); Kajri Jain, 'Studies in Modern Indian Art', *Journal of Arts and Ideas*, Nos 27–28 (March 1995); 'Sites of Art History: Canons and Expositions', *Journal of Arts and Ideas*, Nos 30–31 (December 1997); Rachel Dwyer and Christopher Pinney (eds) *Pleasure and the Nation* (Oxford University Press, 2001); Ashish Rajadhyaksha and Paul Willemen, *Encyclopedia of Indian Cinema* (Oxford University Press and BFI Publishing, 1994); and Tapati Guha Thakurta, *Monuments, Objects, Histories: Institutions of Art in Colonial and Postcolonial India* (Permanent Black, 2004).

[10] Anuradha Kapur, 'Deity to Crusader: The Changing Iconography of Ram' in Gyanendra Pandey (ed.), *Hindus and Others: The Question of Identity in India Today* (Viking Books, 1993), pp. 74–109; and Christopher Pinney, *Photos of the Gods*.

These images are thus appropriable by the aggressive Hindutva brigade, while at the same time, rural dalits too can stake a claim to them. On their part, ACKs seek to occupy a middle ground, in an attempt to assert their distinctiveness from what they consider to be the vulgar address of bazaar iconography. The use of the comic medium, along with the awareness that they are addressing a young, largely urban and middle-class audience results in the creation of a very different dynamic. But insofar as they reproduce a similar iconography, based on photographic realism, there is an intimate connection with this largely religious genre.

II

The comic medium with its action-oriented panels is what most distinguishes ACK from the bulk of mythological-nationalist posters and calendars. Their motion seems to align them with film rather than photographic imagery as discussed earlier. Using Barthes' analogy in 'The Rhetoric of the Image', we learn that while photographic reality involves an awareness of 'having been there', and 'the stupefying evidence of this is how it was, giving us, by a precious miracle a reality from which we are sheltered', the film medium involves an awareness of 'being there' rather than 'having been there'. Just as the photographic image is related to 'a pure spectatorial consciousness', the film medium depends on 'a more projective, more "magical" fictional consciousness'.[11] The photograph can at best represent 'a flat anthropological fact', it cannot aspire to history on its own. The film on the other hand, with its present continuous narrative can establish links and therefore construct a story. In short, it is possible to draw an analogy between the photographic image and the iconic/mythic image on the one hand, and the cinematic image and the narrativising/historicising impulse of the comic on the other. The need for drawing such an analogy rests precisely in the fact that this division can never be too neat. Its two sides often overlap in the way that history and mythology overlap, making it easy to infuse mythic and historical narratives with the single spirit of Indianness.

[11] Roland Barthes, 'The Rhetoric of the Image' in Ann Gray, Jim McGuigan and Edward Arnold (eds), *Studying Culture: An Introductory Reader* (1993), p. 23.

At the same time, the written word, however minimal, carries its own authority. According to Barthes, the linguistic message is present in every image: as title, caption, accompanying press article, film dialogue and comic strip balloon. These messages tend to perform two functions with regard to the iconic image—anchorage and relay. The anchorage text directs 'the reader through the signifieds of the image causing him to avoid some and receive others, by means of an often subtle dispatching, it remote-controls him towards a meaning chosen in advance'.[12] The relay text on the other hand is no more than 'a scratch of a dialogue'. It is complementary to the image, 'the words in the same way as the images are fragments of a more general syntagm and the unity of the message is realized at a higher level than that of the story, the anecdote, the diegesis'.[13] Specifically in terms of the comic medium then, the anchorage text corresponds to the word caption while the relay text corresponds to the word balloon. The former becomes an occasion to display the overt ideology conforming to the dominant social/political morality while the latter simply has the functionalist job of orienting the utterances of the different actors into the right position, adding only those meanings that are not found in the image itself.

Let us see how the words aid and abet the reading of the images. For instance, how are we to read the consolidated image from a mythic structure when it enters a narrative/secular frame? Rarely does the still image lose the ritual meaning associated with it, even if it is put into the service of a narrative. In addition, the representational techniques deployed to grant a sensuousness to reality, such as foreshortening, depth of field, perspective, and shadows all derive from different artistic-historical contexts, investing them with highly codified meanings. Unlike words, pictures 'tend to impress themselves on us at a deep, subliminal level and to stay with us, influencing our thoughts and actions as much, if not more than words do'.[14] For Barthes, 'images are polysemous', they imply beneath their signifiers 'a floating chain' of signifieds, the reader able to choose some and ignore others'.[15] Thus even as both the linguistic message and the pictorial message cannot be

[12] Ibid., p. 20

[13] Ibid., p. 21.

[14] Elizabeth Chaplin, *Sociology and Visual Representation* (Routledge, 1994), p. 3.

[15] Roland Barthes, 'The Rhetoric of the Image', p. 19.

simply denotative, there is a qualitative difference between the denotative function of a visual image and that of a linguistic message. The purpose of the anchorage text is precisely to curb the connotative message of the image. In ACKs, for instance, the anchorage text is deployed to say things which will steer the visuals clear of the censors, even at times by implying meanings which entirely contradict the picture.

There could be an anchorage text that remains tight-lipped about something which finds elaborate exposition through pictures. For instance, in *Guru Nanak* (fig. 1.1), we have a panel which is divided

Fig. 1.1

into three frames headed by the words: 'During his wide travels, he enlightened and reformed many souls. Among them were Sajjan the thug, Kauda the cannibal and Nurshah.' Each of the three frames illustrates the encounter between Nanak and the souls he rescues. While the first two characters are assigned roles which mark them as objects of reform, the third is merely a name, not followed by an epithet, assigned no specific role. It is the image alone which gives a referent and specific content for the name. Sajjan the thug falls repentant at Nanak's feet; Kauda the cannibal is a demon, hairy and with canine teeth, gazing at Nanak who stands at the opening of the cave, sunlight streaming through his golden robes. Nurshah, we conclude from the image-text, must be a courtesan, revealed not only by her costume but also from the decanter and wine placed between Nanak and her curva-

ceous figure. Thus in the gallery of sinful people, a woman's name is enough to signify her as a prostitute. The children who are meant to be protected by the word-text's omission of the appellation 'courtesan' or 'prostitute' in connection with Nurshah, could draw far more ingenious inferences from the sensual and suggestive image-text.

ACKs deliberately exploit the uneven split between the visual projected as popular and the textual as élite, to legitimise its own version of history. While the multi-accentuated visuals emerge as the true site of signification, the guarded words are indicative of the censors that would not allow the true history to be spoken out. The word bubbles are in that sense merely bubbles, evasive about the true nature of the Indian state or its past, pointing towards the visuals for greater enlightenment. We shall look at a few panels from the *Rani Durgavati* comic to illustrate this (figs 1.2a, b).

In the first frame the Rani is shown sitting majestically astride a horse, a cloud of smoke bellowing behind her to suggest furious riding, as she wields a spear in her hand. Several brown, bare-bodied men

Figs 1.2a & 1.2b

wearing ornate headgear with feathers and horns are shown fleeing in the foreground. They are dark-complexioned and the whites of their petrified eyes are shown bulging prominently. One man is shown clutching his head in despair as the Rani presumably strikes the fear of death in him. The written caption merely says, 'the Rani declared many wars'. We know from the previous panels that these wars were declared on the small neighbouring tribal kingdoms in order to replenish the Rani's empty treasury. The continuing frame shows the queen standing imperiously over one of her Gond tribesmen. She herself was a princess of Chandela who chose to marry the son of a Gond tribal chief. The tip of her sword is pointed at one of the tribals as she warns him, 'you can loot as much as you like, but don't dare harm the city folk.' Surrounding them is hectic plunder. There is gold peeping out of the chests and caskets as the Gond men help themselves to the treasures of their neighbouring brothers; one Gond man on the right hand corner is shown clutching a golden vase, his face glowing with greed. One can see that racial signifieds are floating beneath the cartoons, even as the text makes no reference to them, at least overtly.

The writing in the succeeding panel picks up a single message, that of the Rani's noble, altruistic nature, whereas the picture communicates an entirely different subtext. As the men carry the loot to fill the Rani's coffers, she is shown standing in a typically masculine posture, ramrod straight and arms akimbo. The words assert her philanthropy: 'Now we must think about the welfare of the state.' The written text is completely innocent of the imperialist intentions of the Rani, even as it elsewhere berates Akbar for coveting other people's territory.

The anchorage function of the text is evident in so far as it steers clear of the racist content of the images. The ethnic features of the Gond tribesmen are exaggerated to fit into the 'picturesque', even as their actual conduct is shown to be contemptible. They are timid yet greedy and the Rani is hard put to trust her own men. Yet, even without the help of this guiding text, we would still see the queen in a glorious light. Her nobility stands above any intimation of high-handedness that she may display vis-à-vis her tribal subjects. In fact, what we see as high-handedness appears in the benevolent light of a highly approved paternalistic gesture. It is assumed as natural that the Rani, as a fair-skinned upper-caste woman would form the point of identity for the reader of ACK. It is beyond the purview of the ACK reader to identify with the tribals. Consequently, each and every gesture of the

queen, whether imperious or charitable, can only be seen from the vantage point of a moral high ground which the reader shares with her. The rapacious behaviour of the Rani will not be seen as such, since imperialism is only to be associated with outsiders or foreigners, not with the rightful rulers who are only there for the good of the tribals. So when Akbar is denigrated in ACK, it is not because of his imperialist tendencies, but because he is a faithless foreigner.

This logic of the foreigner invariably raises the question of the Rani's status among the Gonds, even as it is quickly submerged in an act of benevolent despotism, where the onus is on the tribals to show their gratitude to the Rani who sacrificed her racial purity by marrying one of them. Her masculinised body language then is not so much an index of bellicosity, but rather a posture befitting a worthy protector. Moreover, Rani Durgavati's story is catalogued not under the historical series, but in 'legend' or 'tale', pointing thus to the representational economy in which women fit. It is crucial from the point of view of ACK's saleability that women be shown in empowering and masculinised postures to produce novelty in the monotonous narrative of Muslim versus Hindu in the medieval period. Also the tribals become mere instruments to enhance women's superiority in this particular frame.

The visuals in the comics certainly do not exist in a vacuum. Insofar as ACK harks back to a utopian past of aristocratic privilege, it produces a dream in which wishes are fulfilled through a market and state apparatus falling in line with, rather than interrupting, the demands of a heterogeneous audience. Quite evidently, ACKs had not factored in the differential needs of a diverse audience base by 15 April 1976, the date of this comic (the 93rd title). Indeed the need to be politically correct and not offend different minority communities was a function of the 1980s, from when ACK began to take its status as a cultural commodity seriously, and consequently, began attempts to mask and package itself as an altruistic gift to the children of India.

III

ACK is a cultural product in a goods and services industry. Drawing upon Adorno, Nicholas Garnham describes culture industries as 'those institutions in our society which employ the characteristic modes of production and organisation of industrial corporation to produce and disseminate symbols in the form of cultural goods and services generally, although not exclusively as commodities'.[16] According to Garnham, profit maximisation takes place in these sectors through audience maximisation, which in turn relies on novelty and difference. Thus there is 'a constant need to create new products which are all in a sense proto-types'.[17] The costs of production being much higher than the return from every copy, the only way for making a profit in this sector is to expand sales and hence the audience base. The initial decade of ACK was characterised by this need to diversify and expand the audience base, reaching a large cross-section of the population. The marketing was previously focused on the domestic audience. But this stable domestic market was gradually abandoned as a more lucrative but narrow market emerged abroad, in tandem with the affluent class of Indians getting further enriched as a result of economic liberalisation.

Since ACKs enjoyed a monopoly in the field of comics publishing, it segmented this market by re-packaging its titles in new volumes of tens and threes. Special bumper issues and deluxe issues were also published. Old issues were brought under politically appealing banners like 'the land of five rivers' published in the early 1980s when the Punjab crisis was at its peak. The cultural product that is ACK was spread across other media as well, such as LP records, audio cassettes, videos, and so on, to reduce the risks involved in selling a single product. However, the fact that it never sold well in any but the comic form indicates that its popularity was a result of the differentiated readership it spawned through its affordable and accessible network of distribution. The culturally high-end products it fashioned in the 1980s by upgrading the quality and technology did not create new audiences.

The attempt to sell off the rights of the regional language comics to local publishers and distributors through the late 1980s and early 1990s is part of this segmentation strategy. The price of the English-language ACK was hiked up in comparison to the others, by virtue of its improved paper quality and colours. The differential status of the English ACK was further reinforced by bringing out a selection of a mere 100 titles, while the remaining titles were put on the backburner or shelved. Moreover, these 100 titles had evidently been selected by the editor for their selling potential within a Hindu-dominated non-

[16] Nicholas Garnham, 'Concepts of Culture: Public Policies and the Cultural Industries' in Ann Gray et al., *Studying Culture*, p. 55.

[17] Ibid., p. 57.

resident Indian market. One could argue then that a loosely defined secular market was given up for a more lucrative albeit narrowly Hinduised market, which invariably came to influence the reception of the comics along religious lines. This led to the comics being received along religious lines.

The present management holds Anant Pai as the brain behind these marketing strategies. But while the initial experiments at conception and production are entirely attributable to him, it is not very clear whether the IBH played a role in this market segmentation. The editorial staff, illustrators, letterists and other production staff were completely under Pai's hierarchical supervision. Rarely does one hear of any role played by H.G. Mirchandani, the proprietor of IBH, in the evolving policy decisions. Yet surely, the considerations for marketing changes must have been the result of an interplay of editorial and management concerns.

The reinvention of ACK as a quasi-public educational institution and as a Trust grew out of its increasing sensitivity to the different claims and censors operative in civil society. It was ACK's self-styled investment in the figure of the child which lay behind the comic overreacting to the demands of individuals and institutions, thus rendering itself vulnerable to attacks. The only way it could force or retain its original agenda then, was through a certain subterfuge and games of hide and seek between the overtly articulated anchorage text and the subliminal picture codes.

IV

The purpose of children's literature, Peter Hunt tells us, is seen in terms of 'its effectiveness for education, language acquisition, socialisation/acculturation or for entertainment'.[18] ACK seems to keep these points in mind while planning its self-publicity. Its endeavours to become an effective pedagogical tool are seen, for instance, in its much publicised attempt to hold a seminar on 'The Role of Chitra Katha in School Education' in February 1978. ACK insists that the comic medium it uses has native antecedents rather than having been borrowed from western comics. The fact that it has been inspired by

[18] Peter Hunt, *Criticism, Theory and Children's Literature* (Blackwell Publishers, 1991), p. 43.

indigenous bas reliefs at Bharhut, Sanchi and Ajanta helps to establish its value as a guide to cultural heritage.

At the same time, ACK strives to maintain its status in the fun industry, indicated by its willingness to adapt and upgrade itself to technological change. The striking thing, however, about this willingness to update is that it has not really translated into a really popular product in any other media. While it is true that audio cassettes, LPs and video cassettes have reared their heads from time to time, they haven't really had a life other than in the advertisements. In fact, ACK always seems to be on the brink of starting an animation series, however, the fact that it has not managed to do this only serves to prove that it does not take the threat of technological obsolescence very seriously. The resilience of the comic medium seems to have absorbed any setbacks it might have suffered for not upgrading itself.

Thus, these different claims to adhere to a simplified, child-friendly ethos combines both reified notions of childhood, and the fear that this group will outgrow its need for this kind of literature very soon. This accounts for the need to keep one foot each in the juvenile literature market, as well as the larger culture industry oriented to games and gizmos, much more amenable to an amorphously classified youth industry.

Perhaps this explains the tendency in ACK to counter the dominant ideals of children's literature practitioners. The child audience projected through ACK does not embody spontaneity, purity and natural virtue. There is no real concern to protect children from depictions of violence or sexuality. Instead there is a sense that the child needs first to seize control over contested national goods. The different tales of intrigue, competition, sly wit and infighting are intended to infuse the child with an audacious pragmatism. Ultimately, this emphasis on street savvyness results from the view that the child needs to outgrow his/her childhood really fast, in order to be able to contribute to the national economy. According to the authors of *How to Read Donald Duck*, 'the adult corroded by the trivia of everyday life blindly defends his image of youth and innocence. Because of this, it [children's literature] is perhaps (and least expected) the best place to study the disguises and truths of contemporary man'.[19]

However, for the most part, ACKs do not include children in their narratives. Children, if at all presented, are adults read back into their

[19] Ariel Dorfman and Armand Mattelart, *How to Read Donald Duck*, p. 31.

formative years, their childhood inflected with signs of heroism and martyrdom. The Freedom Fighters series manifests this tendency most prominently. In some senses, of course, the entire ACK corpus may be read into the Freedom Fighter series. The bulk of saints, religious leaders, and great men and women all fall into the hagiographical mode. Yet the hagiography has certain conditions. Unlike the bourgeois children's literature, in ACKs, the two domains of the family home and the classroom are not necessarily seen as the natural home of the child. In fact, there is a subtle antagonism between these two spaces. While the school is urgently in need of reform, home has its own sets of restrictions and taboos. Nevertheless it is seen as providing a refuge from school. The home too might turn into an inimical space, because of the nagging mother figure as in *Raman Maharshi*, or the grandmother who will not let the child Shankar Dev take up the ascetic's life. In the Revolutionary series of course, there is a need to portray the mother as Mother India, the main inspiration behind the son's patriotism. However, judging by the more frenzied deification of Mother India in the popular visual domain, from the late 19th century to the present, ACKs tribute to the Mother India trope is rather mild. In fact, women as *satis* rather than mother figures were seen to be better triggers for men to get their act together. Unless it was absolutely and historically necessary to show women in the mother mode—the various narratives of Bankim Chandra such as *Devi Choudhurani* and *Kapala Kundala*, or the figure of Jijabai in *Shivaji*—ACKs refrained from invoking the mother figure very liberally.

Perhaps the freedom imperative of the narrative, which needed the protagonist to leave both home and school in order to explore a wider world, was the reason for this toning down of the mother image. For the mystic or the freedom lover, the home was definitely oppressive. At the same time, while the *gurukul* or the school sequestered in the lap of nature was idealised, it was not so much this quality that was the object of eulogy as the fact that they were places where one learned the first lessons in contending schools of scholarship. In fact, a truly great student could even learn to challenge his/her own mentor and teach him a thing or two. It is important to remember that in tandem with the pre-bourgeois tendencies in ACKs, the world beyond these two institutions was not constructed as a scene of adventure. On the contrary, this larger domain encompassing scenes of conflict, violence and brutalisation of women, was seen as a necessary exposure for child readers in order for them to get on in life, rather than something their tender nature had to be protected from.

This need to please two masters, an anachronistic but persisting feudal system invoked by the mythic structure on the one hand, and the contemporary bourgeois audience for whom the mythic structure is invoked on the other, led ACK to adopt a selective method in terms of the glamorisation of violence and sex. The conflicts shown in ACKs were therefore clothed in iconoclasm or heroism to negotiate their place in children's literature. Similarly, the communal, sexist and racial overtones one found in the comic were invariably shielded by the logic of being drawn from a pre-capitalist mode of production.

A look at the larger ethos within which the cultural interventions of ACK were formulated would help us understand ACK's iconoclastic agenda. Some of the landmarks in the history of the institutionalisation of a child culture in the post-Independence phase are given below.

The Children's Film Society started making films for children in 1955.
The Children's Book Trust was established in 1957 under the helmsmanship of K. Shankar Pillai, the renowned cartoonist who also instituted the world famous children's painting competition in 1949.
The National Council of Educational Research and Training was established in 1961.
The National Book Trust was established in 1964.
The B.C. Roy Library in Delhi was set up under Shankar's direction in 1967.
1979 was declared the International Year of the Child.
The First National Children's Book Fair was held in Calcutta in 1983; this was accompanied by the flooding of the Indian market with Soviet children's books that were promoted in different languages.
1985–86 was declared the UNICEF year of the girl child.
1990 was the International Literacy Year.
1991 was the SAARC year of the girl child and 1990–2000, the SAARC decade of the girl child.

These interventions were part of an attempt to ameliorate the structural failings in the domain of education, health, gender discrimination and other basic rights of survival, if not civic rights. The glaring shortcomings of the state's commitment to provide free and compulsory education to everyone under the age of 14 under Article

45 of the Constitution were perhaps the biggest of such failures. If we were to take a look at the critical assessment of this failure to universalise education, it might read something like the Nauni Declaration of the Lokshala Programme for universalisation of Elementary Education:

> We do not regard education as a means for converting the child into a 'national resource', an 'input' into the national economy or a 'useful product'.... Instead, the schools need to be transformed into community managed social institutions (rather than being viewed as state-controlled prescriptions) where children first understand the world they live in, then participate in it and eventually intervene to re-define it.[20]

The above passage articulates a position which nevertheless presumes a bourgeois framework, where children are to be provided a differential time and space for growth. This explains the significance of painting competitions, and special films and radio programmes for them. At the same time, it might send panic signals running through a certain section of the middle class by saying that children ought not to be viewed as 'an "input" into the national economy'. This is the middle-class opinion which ACK represents and speaks for, and for whom the market and the national economy are crucial, to the extent that education is an investment which must pay off.

Thus a non-instrumentalist 'progressive' education à la the Lokshala Project might not really be seen as feasible in terms of its economic pay-offs. The absence of exams and hence sharp assessment procedures synonymous with a meritocratic system is seen to be as threatening as the state's need to be partial to some underprivileged communities. The granting of special concessions or quotas to a variety of deprived communities could perhaps be seen as synonymous with a dismissal of the brahmin's privileged status. After all, how can one effectively claim privileges for one's brahminical or upper caste status within a system defined by bourgeois individuality? 'Merit' becomes a means for continuing and legitimising one's privileged status. If caste status is effaced and social superiority instead naturalised in terms of merit, which is itself the combination and culmination of

20 *The Lokshala Project for Universalisation of Elementary Education: Demonstrating an Alternate Vision*, Bharat Jan Vigyan Jatha & MACESE, Department of Education, University of Delhi, 31 March 1995.

different kinds of social and cultural capital, then the older caste equations can remain intact.

V

Strikingly disproportionate to its commercial success, the current state of secondary literature on ACK consists only of a heap of newspaper articles and a couple of academic essays in anthologies and journals. The volume *Media and Transformation of Religion in South Asia*, published in 1995 was the first to include two essays on this 'blockbuster' consumable of contemporary India. In the opening essay, 'The World of Amar Chitra Katha', Frances Pritchett examines the public policies of ACK. The piece critically evaluates ACK's taxonomising logic and draws attention to the ideological orientation of Anant Pai which determines and negotiates the policies on the conflicting claims of the minority communities. There is also a limited criticism of ACK's Hindu bias, citing the absence of a Muslim figure in the 'Makers of Modern India' series. Pritchett goes on to highlight the fact that representations of British colonial officers have not been as detailed as the rough-cut villains of the Mughal period. She notes the racial visualisation of the ACK drawings, and the rationalistic humanisation of its depiction of animals (animals drawn into the human form). By and large, her essay is a balance sheet of good and bad and the final word is a commendation of the series' humanitarian effort, which bears overlooking the 'minor glitches'. For example, she says, 'Readers who happen to be of the wrong gender, the wrong politics, or the wrong religion will find themselves only scantily represented.' At the same time, ACK readers will be led

> to hate untouchability and to feel outrage at the plight of the poor and to admire the gallant deeds of at least some women and some non-Hindus. And they will never...feel hostility towards one another. They will have a strong positive sense of India as a multicultural nation in which they can all work together.[21]

21 Frances Pritchett, 'The World of Amar Chitra Katha', in Lawrence A. Babb and Susan S. Wadley (eds), *Media and Transformation of Religion in South Asia*, University of Pennsylvania Press, 1995, p. 105.

A liberal reading of this kind fails precisely because it refuses to acknowledge the ideological underpinnings of an image, or look at the inequality and oppression elided in the presentation of a multi-cultural India. Whose model of multi-culturalism is ACK talking about after all? Whose interests are served by it? If as Pritchett says, women, non-Hindus and those who are not happy within the feudal-capitalist mode of production are going to be alienated by the ACK vision, it leaves a very small readership of urban middle-class boys. As is evident from the phenomenal success of ACK among a wider cross-section, this is clearly not the case. In the present volume, an attempt will also be made to counter simplified readings of this type. The focus will, however, be on the manner in which ACK garners the sympathy of precisely those it leaves out from its pages.

The second essay in *Media and Transformation*, 'The Saints Subdued: Domestic Virtue and National Integration in Amar Chitra Katha' is by John Stratton Hawley. Hawley's piece limits itself to the hagiographies of six Hindu saints with respect to the traditionally extant versions on their lives. The aim is to see 'the process of selection that makes an Amar Chitra Katha saint a saint'. His aim is also to elaborate Pai's theological commitments as worked into the martrix of these hagiographies, 'especially his vision of the inclusiveness of truth'.[22] Hawley exposes Pai's paradoxical position as a scientific rationalist who refused to publish issues with an excess of superstition and dogma, such as Santoshi Mata and Vaishno Devi, and yet when it came to depicting certain saints, there was no problem with venturing into the miraculous. The suppressing of the politically reformist content of the saints' teachings is evident in the accent on their personal transcendence and the sidelining of the saints' attack on the caste system.

Hawley describes ACK as a quasi-public institution but also sees Pai's complicity in games with political parties. Unlike Pritchett, he recognises that the line between Indian and Hindu is a blurred one and that, '"Hinduism" as a distinct internally consistent system running parallel with other "religions" is an invention of the 19th century'.[23] Yet he is shy of drawing the connection between ACK and Hindutva politics. While it would certainly be premature to identify ACK with an outright communal project, it makes use of the seemingly 'secular' Hindu symbols and icons to naturalise its universal claim upon a national ethos. What does this mean? Does it mean that a modern secular discourse must avoid discussion of religious issues at any cost? Or does it indicate the manner in which the de-sacralisation of images brought about by the techniques of mechanical reproduction has invariably turned images into political weapons?

[22] John Stratton Hawley, 'The Saints Subdued', in Lawrence A. Babb and Susan S. Wadley (eds), *Media and Transformation of Religion*, pp. 105–7.

[23] Ibid., p. 108

How does the sacred become political? 'The Modern Re-Appropriation of Myth'[24] by Hassan Khan tries to explain precisely that. The author attempts to explain how the symbolic structure of a myth is capable of manipulating the positioning of the audience/reader to invoke identities which are resonant with different political ends, whether to serve the nation or its corollary modernity with its compulsive consumerist patterns. He chooses localised instances of two specific texts, the *Jaiminiya Brahamana*, the *Mahabharata* and one issue of the ACK title *Sukanya* for a comparative analysis to demonstrate how a myth is re-appropriated in the modern public sphere. The most important contribution of Hassan's essay is his attempt to see the popular comic on par with these 'classical texts', rather than as a corruption of a 'loftier textual tradition'.

'Colourful Comics, Epidermal Politics: Symbolic Illustrations of Skin Colour in *Amar Chitra Katha*' by Radhika Parameswaran and Kavitha Cordoza[25] seeks 'to pose new questions about the representational politics of skin colour in national contexts that seemingly have homogeneous "brown" racial communities, namely India'. For instance how do hierarchies based on skin colour produce hegemonic versions of masculinity, class, religion, region, caste, and race? Parameswaran and Cordoza understand this appropriately within the larger cultural commodity status of ACK, through what they refer to as 'a loosely integrated entertainment and self-improvement empire'. Through a detailed analysis of the economies of colour in the thematisation of race and caste in the comics, they flesh out the truism that dark-skinned women are seen as masculine.

Karline Mclain's Ph.D. dissertation, 'Whose Immortal Picture Stories? Amar Chitra Katha and the Construction of Indian

[24] Hassan Khan, 'The Modern Reappropriation of Myth' in *Alif: Journal of Comparative Poetics*, No. 18, Post-Colonial Discourse in South Asia/ Khitab Ma Bad al-Kuluniyaliyah fi Junub Asya, 1998, pp. 174–204, accessed from http://www.jstor.org on 15 April 2006.

[25] Radhika Parameswaran and Kavitha Cordoza, 'Colourful Comics, Epidermal Politics: Symbolic Illustrations in *Amar Chitra Katha*', Conference Papers, International Communications Association, 2005 Annual Meeting, New York.

Identities'[26] is a substantial work insofar as it provides a wealth of detail about the inner functioning of the ACK empire (the author having spent a year in the ACK office, interacting with the editors, illustrators and other staff members). She organises her chapters in a very interesting manner, around particular ACK issues such as *Krishna*, *Durga*, *Shakuntala*, *Shivaji*, *Shahajahan*, *Aurangzeb* and *Mahatma Gandhi*, using them to enter the symbolic world of religion, gender and community as invoked by ACK. Evident in this dissertation is thorough scholarship, as well as familiarity with current events and the political everyday of the Indian nation insofar as they touch upon reader response.

The scholars above recognise that myths are antiquarian, belonging to a different order of morality altogether, and therefore cannot be inserted into present-day dominant narratives, whether communal or otherwise, without mediation from interested parties. This is distinct from simply saying that the mythic structure lends itself to politicised interpretations. The highlight if any, of the present work is to foreground the process through which the communal colour emerges as not merely an inevitable function of a sacred content, but that of a carefully constructed sacred. The point of this book is to probe beneath the offered rationalisations and look for reasons other than those offered by the different individuals responsible for the creation of ACK. At its simplest, this book strives for a radical alertness to ACK's imperative to look beyond the words at what is going on outside the bubble in which they are contained.

I do not pretend here to deal with all the 440 ACK titles nor to present an exhaustive analysis. The ACKs used for this study are mostly picked at random from the pavements of Daryaganj for not more than five rupees each. The randomness of the selection though may have helped me to find things which I would have missed, had I selected them on an a priori basis.

When I revisited the project in 2005 and met Uncle Pai again, along with the proprietors, new editors, illustrators, finance managers, others from the comic industry, readers, those who were doing research on the comics or seeking to make films on them, I realised that the entire field had shifted radically from when I started my

26 Karline Mclain, 'Whose Immortal Pictures? Amar Chitra Katha and the Construction of Indian Identities', unpublished Ph.D. thesis submitted at the University of Texas at Austin (May 2005), accessed online at http://dspace.lib.utexas.edu/bitstream/2152/416/1/mclain33750.pdf on 27 February 2007.

research in 1995. Ram Waeerkar, the illustrator had told me then that I was the first researcher who had visited him with regard to a scholarly work on ACK. Now, the popular has taken on a new avatar as popular chic. In the light of its new respectability, there is burgeoning interest in the category. Also, a focus on Hindutva politics, which had admittedly spurred me on in the 1990s seems to have become decidedly un-hip. In my earlier thesis, I had suggested that ACKs were part of a Hindu consciousness that was at least a hundred and fifty years old, emerging in the late 19th century, as it were. This time over, I discovered that it was in part the result of a brahminical consensus that was much older. In fact, the utter depth of the historical process is precisely what makes the various players innocent of its stakes. They see themselves not as the stormtroopers of a vicious cultural hegemony, but rather as people simply doing their jobs; of course, they also consider themselves as having the freedom to fight what they do not like. And yet, each of them is conscious of having contributed to something bigger than him/herself, which is visible in the love and dedication they bestow upon their work.